

A Thin Veiled Night

Under the Dome

writer: d.b.j

EXT. SCOTT PARK / FREE BRIDGE - NIGHT

Dry maple waits by a brick fire ring on the Easton bank where the Lehigh meets the Delaware hard. Lamps on the Free Bridge lay a yellow band over the current toward Phillipsburg. Once sunset clears the West Ward roofs, chill climbs off the confluence and owns the shore. Gears change on Larry Holmes Drive. North of here a freight runs the river line.

JONAH DERR (22) sits near the heat on a flipped bucket. A few faces across the ring hold sticks and paper cups. Bridge light lays a pale stripe across the water and leaves the far bank dark.

JONAH (V.O.)

Pull that dry maple in before the river damp gets into it. My name is Jonah Derr. I'm twenty-two. This is about a portable planetarium dome at Nurture Nature Center, and about a stuck gear tooth that finished a choice my mouth had already lost.

Jonah feeds maple until flame climbs the ring. River damp and wood smoke mix. Across the water Phillipsburg's windows stay a thin glow. He keeps one eye on the unspent sticks and one on the faces that came to listen.

JONAH (V.O.)

I was eighteen the April night the science club rented the inflatable dome and hauled it into the education hall at 518 Northampton Street.

CUT TO:

INT. NURTURE NATURE CENTER / EDUCATION HALL - DAY (APRIL)

Brick and glass face the downtown sidewalk by the circle and market stalls. In a dark corner a Science on a Sphere globe turns slow. Parents hand five dollars across a folding table. Kids claim a stamped ticket and a

photocopied star chart. Block print in the corner reads APRIL 12.

A box fan rattles like loose change in a dryer. White fabric climbs into a dome over the floor. JONAH (18) holds a seam. TYLER BRANDT (19), crew-thick through the chest, walks the skirt and pins it so coats will not catch when the lights drop.

TYLER

Once you map it, it's mapped. Big
Bang, stellar fusion, gravity
wells. You don't need a Person
after that. Explained means
finished. Leave the hymns for the
people who can't read a chart.

Jonah keeps the wrench on the bolts. Pushing Tyler mid-setup is like shouting at a fan already spinning. Noise and heat arrive. The bolts still need turns.

MS. VARGO, the club adviser, taps a clear cover on the projector cradle in the middle of the inflated room. Beneath it a metal gear ring carries a small plastic tooth that engages the sky wheel when software asks for a season change. Blue painter's tape holds a faded co-op inventory sticker to the case lid, half peeled, coffee smear across the barcode. That smear does no other work. It only sits.

MS. VARGO

If it sticks, don't force it. Back
the wheel off and free the tooth
by hand. These units chew
themselves if you lean on the
motor.

INT. DOME / EDUCATION HALL - DAY (4PM DRY SHOW)

The dome goes black. Stars rise in the software's borrowed order. From a stool Tyler works a headset mic and names Orion, the Dipper, and the ecliptic path with the script cold.

At the season-change cue the gear tooth catches and the wheel stutters, locking the projected sky with March still

hanging where April belongs. Tyler kills the motor under his breath. Jonah slides two fingers under the cover, lifts the tooth clear of a plastic burr on the ring, and reseats it until the wheel runs smooth.

From the door, Ms. Vargo claps once.

MS. VARGO

Keep those hands ready for the
public hour.

INT. DOME / EDUCATION HALL - NIGHT (7PM PUBLIC SHOW)

Coats and wet shoes fill the hall. Burned popcorn drifts from the staff microwave. Jonah works tickets at the folding table until the last family ducks under the dome flap. He tears stubs and stacks cash in a metal box labeled SKY NIGHT. Then he slides in and sits on the floor with his back to the cradle, chart on his knees, a stamped stub still warm in his hoodie pocket.

Tyler opens on light-years, fusion, and the age of the cosmos as if those figures were a lid screwed tight. Through the wall the Sphere hums in the outer room. Outside, Friday traffic on Northampton runs toward the Free Bridge. Inside, the sky wheels and kids point at the borrowed stars.

A little girl in a pink coat raises her hand.

PINK-COAT GIRL

Did God put the stars up?

Tyler laughs once through the mic.

TYLER

Science put the map together.
That's enough of an answer for
anybody who wants a real one.
Explained. Next question.

The girl goes quiet. Her mother rests a hand on the pink sleeve. Jonah keeps his mouth shut. The show belongs to Tyler. Jonah is the tooth guy.

At the season-change cue the gear sticks again.

Projected sky freezes on a winter belt while every lap chart says April. The motor whines. Tyler puts weight on the control tablet the way a man leans on a stuck bolt. The tooth clicks dry against the burr and will not take the next notch. A boy in the second row says the Dipper looks tipped.

Ms. Vargo calls from the flap, voice low and clear.

MS. VARGO

Jonah. Hands.

Jonah skips the speech. Talk will not free a projector tooth, and it will not turn a friend who already decided a named mechanism shuts every door the mechanism never opened. He crawls to the cradle on his knees, lifts the clear cover, and sets his fingers on the plastic tooth the way he did at four. The burr sits higher from the earlier catch. The tooth hangs half engaged. The wheel binds. Software still asks for a sky the hardware will not give.

TYLER

Force it. We have a schedule. The sky is explained either way. The date on the chart is a printout. Reality is the math.

Jonah's hands stay on the tooth. Cradle edge digs into his wrist. Lamp heat climbs through the metal. Warm dust and popcorn burn hang in the air.

JONAH

If I force it, we chew the ring.
Ms. Vargo said so.

TYLER

Then the show dies on a wrong month and we look like we don't know what we're doing. Push it. Explained is explained. A stuck tooth doesn't open a theology.

Beyond the fabric somebody laughs in the Sphere room. A bus hisses brakes at the Northampton curb. The pink-coat girl holds her chart flat on her knees. APRIL 12 block print sits clear under the dome's leftover glow.

Jonah eases the wheel back the way Ms. Vargo showed them. The tooth slips free in his fingers: small white plastic, worn face, hairline crack he missed at four. He lifts it so the lamp catches the crack. Then he parks it in his palm and does not reseal it.

JONAH

We're done with the motor. We'll finish on the real sky. Charts out. Coats on. Spotting scopes are already on the rolling cart by the Pine Street door. Ms. Vargo?

Ms. Vargo holds the flap open with her shoulder and waves the line toward the hall.

MS. VARGO

Walk them down toward Scott Park. Stay on the sidewalk. Jonah has the tooth. Tyler, bring the cart.

Tyler stares at Jonah's open palm. The cracked tooth rests there like a bad punchline. He kills the tablet, yanks the headset, and for a second his mouth works without sound. Then he stands and grabs the cart handle hard enough that the scopes rattle in their foam.

EXT. NORTHAMPTON STREET / DOWNTOWN EASTON - NIGHT

Two dozen people spill from 518 Northampton into April dark. Center windows throw rectangles on the sidewalk. The line heads for the river past the circle and market block, coats zipped, charts flapping on belt loops and stroller handles. On the corner a shopkeeper drops a metal grate over a window. The grate rings once at the stop.

EXT. SCOTT PARK / OVERLOOK RAIL - NIGHT

Cold Delaware opens wide at Larry Holmes Drive. Scott Park spreads under Free Bridge lamps with the confluence dark

past the rail. Phillipsburg windows sit across the current like a second, smaller map. A heron holds the shallows below the dam and stays put when a truck crosses the span.

Tyler sets a spotting scope on a pad by the overlook rail. He checks the finder, swings toward Vega's neighborhood, and curses because the rechargeable pack on the mount went dead between afternoon check and night use. The spare scope's pack still holds charge. He swaps batteries with his jaw tight, thumbs power until the mount wakes, and the eyepiece locks on a hard white point that is not a planet and not a plane. Jonah keeps the cracked tooth in his fist while Tyler works. Plastic edges press his palm hard enough to leave a mark.

Along the rail the coat line thickens. Kids pin charts to the metal so wind will not steal the paper. Ms. Vargo holds a red flashlight low, names what she can, and keeps the beam off the eyepieces. Tyler recovers his voice and talks mechanisms: fusion, distance, light-speed as a ruler. He is good at it. He always has been.

A father asks why the chart's April sky failed to match the dome before they walked out. Tyler says hardware failure, then says the real sky proves science still owns the night.

Jonah stands with the folding-table stub still in his pocket and the chart in his other hand. Print reads APRIL 12 in Ms. Vargo's block letters. Over the Delaware the April sky shows what bridge glare and downtown wash leave: hard bright points, a few named shapes, and plenty of dark the ink never fills. Water slaps concrete under the rail. A dog barks once toward the bandshell and goes quiet.

Tyler finishes a line about stellar nurseries and turns toward Jonah in the bridge light.

TYLER

You made a scene over a gear. You think a stuck tooth means the universe has a Person in it? That's a gap talking. We name the gap, we close it. That's what explained means.

Jonah opens his hand. The tooth's cracked face catches yellow from the bridge.

JONAH

The dome mapped a sky. The tooth failed the map mid-sentence. We came outside and the battery was dead until you swapped it. The chart still says April and the sky still does what it does whether our motor runs or not. Science is a good servant for the how. It told us the wheel was binding and the pack was flat and which way to point the tube. It did not tell us why there is a sky to map, or why a question keeps standing after the mechanism has a name. You used explained like a lid. That lid never covered the why the how left standing.

Tyler takes the tooth off Jonah's palm, turns it once, and parks it on the rail beside the scope base.

TYLER

Cute. You're preaching with a projector part.

JONAH

I'm telling you what my hands already did. I could have forced the ring and let the show lie about the month so your word stayed tidy. I backed it off. The how still matters. The how is not the whole sentence.

Tyler wipes his palms on denim. A barge light drifts slow on the Delaware toward the bend. The heron lifts and heads upriver into dark. On the New Jersey side a porch bulb blinks out and leaves a darker gap in the window line.

TYLER

I'm not converting. I like the maps. I don't like the Mapper. You

can keep your open questions. I'll
keep calling a finished mechanism
a finished case.

JONAH

I know. I'm not your Holy Spirit.

Ms. Vargo calls time from the rail. They cap the eyepieces,
push the cart back up Larry Holmes toward Northampton, and
count heads at every corner the way she trained them.

INT. NURTURE NATURE CENTER / STORAGE CLOSET - NIGHT

Staff drag the empty dome fabric and the projector cradle
into storage. Jonah sets the cracked tooth on Ms. Vargo's
desk inside a paper cup bearing DO NOT FORCE / REPLACE
RING. She tapes the cup to the case beside the coffee-
smeared inventory sticker and locks the closet. The key
meets her belt ring with a soft click.

EXT. SCOTT PARK / FIRE RING - NIGHT (THAT NIGHT)

A few of them start a small fire in the Scott Park ring the
way the city allows when wind is right and somebody brings
sand. Tyler arrives late with crew sweat still on his
collar. He cracks a can. Jonah cups lukewarm gas-station
coffee and sits without asking who called this.

Tyler skips the tooth at first. He talks practice, a calc
test, and a girl from Phillipsburg who preferred the Sphere
to the stuffed birds upstairs. Then the can tips toward the
dark where the dome had been, uphill and west on
Northampton.

TYLER

You still think God is hiding in a
stuck gear.

JONAH

I think explained has to know its
job. If explained only means we
named a how, then using it to shut
every why is borrowing a bigger
word than the tool earned. You
don't live like the whys are fake.

You get mad when a chart lies. Mad
needs a real line. A servant that
maps the sky is still a servant.

Tyler watches coals. A moth batters the nearest bridge
lamp, drops, climbs again, and keeps trying the same glass.
The Free Bridge hums under a late truck. Yellow on the
water breaks and heals and breaks again.

TYLER
I still sleep fine. You keep your
tooth. I'll keep my lid.

He drinks. Jonah watches a maple knot catch and toss a
brief spark onto brick, where it dies. They do not hug it
out. They do not settle the veil. The Delaware keeps toward
the bend as always. Tyler stays Tyler. Behind a locked
closet door on Northampton Street the cracked tooth sits
taped in a paper cup with the coffee smear still on the
sticker.

CUT TO:

EXT. NORTHAMPTON STREET - DAY (JUNE / LATER)

Jonah works a South Side lumber route now, counting board
feet while forklifts beep in reverse. Tyler left for a
state engineering program. Crossing the block past the
Center, Jonah spots Tyler's car in the opposite lane. Tyler
lifts two fingers off the wheel. Jonah lifts two fingers
back. Neither slows. The river runs the same way it did in
April.

CUT TO:

**EXT. SCOTT PARK / FREE BRIDGE - NIGHT (GROWN CODA / BACK TO
FRAME)**

Jonah (present) builds the fire higher. Maple pops and the
bridge hums. The confluence pulls day's heat off the bank.
Faces across the ring wait without rushing him.

JONAH (V.O.)

I graduated that June and took a year of community college classes while I stacked lumber at a yard on the South Side. Tyler went to a state school for engineering and sends me photos of lab benches when he remembers. Sometimes I see his car on Northampton when I walk past the Center. He lifts two fingers off the wheel. I lift two fingers back. We have not spoken about lids since the night the dome froze on the wrong month.

Jonah feeds maple. Bridge light lays flat on black water. Far bank stays dark where the lamps cannot reach.

JONAH (V.O.)

On nights like this, with the maple smoking and the Free Bridge humming and the confluence taking the day's heat off the bank, I keep the story short. I am not here to close the big question for you. I am here to tell you what a borrowed word sounds like in a friend's mouth when his hands are forcing a gear, and what another man's hands did with a cracked projector tooth when the sky on the cloth stopped matching the date on the chart.

He eyes the spare maple by the ring for whoever sits close enough to reach it.

JONAH (V.O.)

Throw that other piece on. Let the fire see our faces. I like an Easton fire that shows me the bridge and the water both, and leaves the far bank dark where the light can't reach.

FADE OUT.